

Community Informatics and Development

One of the central social processes in information society is of a technology mediated reorganisation of our social relationships and structures in a manner that tends towards 'big systems' rather than small. Economic globalisation is an early manifestation of this process, but information society's big system propensity goes much further into social, cultural and political aspects, increasingly taking control of our lives. It has, therefore, become imperative that advocates and agents of progressive social change operate at two different levels. On the one hand, they need to invest in influencing the nature of technology models that underpin new macro possibilities, through an engagement with ICT governance issues. On the other hand, it is equally important to directly contribute towards creating small counter systems at the peripheries that empower the local against the hegemonic global.

IT for Change's Centre for Community Informatics and Development (CCID) in Mysore works with community based organisations involved with a range of development activities, from women's empowerment to livelihood issues. CCID's activities are aimed at exploring how community development processes can be made participatory and effective through new information and communication systems. We help our partner organisations experiment with uses of technology in their work, which can often have transformative effects. The attempt is always to democratise the use of technology among field workers and community members, rather than developing specialised ICT units to support development work. Knowledge gained from these experiments is ploughed back as we work with more groups and organisations, and is also used for advocacy towards community-centric and empowerment-oriented ICTD policies.

This year, we continued to undertake exciting work in the areas of community radio, community video and community computing in our main test bed among *Mahila Samakhya* Karnataka's (MSK), women's collectives (*sanghas*) in Mysore district of Karnataka state. In addition, we also trained *Vikasana*, an NGO working in the area of livelihoods and gender, in making community radio programs. With the launch of the UNICEF supported project, *Kishori Chitrapata* (Images by adolescent girls), the year 2009-10 marked the beginning of our work in the area of community informatics and education, through a focus on learning processes among out of school adolescent girls.

Community Radio

Kelu Sakhi (Listen, O Friend!) continued to be the 'sangha radio' over this year and is now close to 200 weekly broadcasts. These radio broadcasts enrich the work of MSK among the *sanghas* and

at the village community level. Over the year, two important campaigns were taken up through *Kelu Sakhi*.

The first one was about the importance of attending village assemblies, or the *gram sabhas*. In an eight week long



Recording for
Kelu Sakhi, Hunsur
Taluk, Mysore District,
Karnataka

campaign, the MSK and CCID team did features on the 'why and how' of a *gram sabha*, the funds of a *gram panchayat* (the elected village government) and the duties of elected representatives in the *gram panchayat*. The *sangha* women spoke about their experiences of participating in *gram sabhas* and *gram panchayats*, the hardships they faced and how they were able to overcome these.

This programme was very popular and has had a significant impact. The recordings of interviews with experts regarding *gram sabhas* have been replayed by the MSK's Cluster Resource Persons (CRPs) through local audio systems available at temples and other community spaces. There appears to have been an increase in enthusiasm among community members to attend *gram sabhas*. In *Jabagere* village, for the first time, women started participating in the *gram sabha* after listening to radio programmes. When the village leaders took a decision to allocate *panchayat* money for temple renovation, *sangha* women voiced their dissent and ensured that the money was instead allocated towards housing for the poor.

Another campaign was regarding *gram panchayat* elections. It was aimed at motivating women to contest the elections and thus to increase women's participation in local governance. MSK identified interested women and conducted an orientation for them on the electoral procedure. This included simple as well as complex issues, from how to fill a nomination form to how not to succumb to political pressures. MSK women came on air and spoke about why they had chosen to contest the elections, and the challenges they faced, including those presented by the family, community and officials. The CCID team did features on various topics showcasing women already in politics as well as the reservation policy for women in these institutions and how the collective strength of *sanghas* can have great significance vis-à-vis electoral outcomes. Eighty seven MSK women won the *gram panchayat* elections in Mysore district this year.

The impact of the *Kelu Sakhi* has spread much beyond MSK *sanghas*. Men from the community have started calling in to give favourable feedback for the programmes, interestingly and significantly, identifying themselves in relation to *sangha* women (for instance, men now introduce themselves as 'I am the husband of so and so *sangha* member'). Women from many *sanghas* other than those organised by MSK have called to say how they find the programme highly useful and that the collective listening of the programmes at *sangha* meetings is helping them organise collective action. MSK is finding it much easier to start *sanghas* in new villages where women are listening to *Kelu Sakhi*. These women are more willing and forthcoming to organise into *sanghas*.

ITfC focuses on social processes, which is extremely critical for any long-term involvement with the community. Their work for the *Mahiti Manthana* project holds some important lessons on empowering communities which is worth emulating by others.

Amit Chakravarty, National
Institute of Smart
Government, Hyderabad,
Andhra Pradesh

At CCID, there is a continuous endeavour to develop new and effective techno-social tools and formats that are not resource intensive and are suited to the specific context of local communities. During this past year, each weekly programme was set in a different place with authentic live audio elements from the outdoor as background. The idea of such outdoor live recording was to create mobility for the anchor, as well as to make the programmes richer in audio elements, both of which contributed to an increased effectiveness of the broadcast. Feedback for this format is highly encouraging. Some popular outdoor places and contexts include women compering from Mysore *Dasara* (an important local festival) exhibition, women gathered around campfires during winter and women in hilly areas.

Long familiarity with broadcast has given a sense of ease and ownership to women *vis-à-vis* *Kelu Sakhi* programmes. Women are now much more comfortable to talk about their real opinions and have also started requesting for programmes to be made at their *sanghas*. The *Vox Pop* slot is a newly designed format to go with the increased ease and willingness of women to express themselves. We also experimented with non-scripted programmes. One such popular programme was about women giving a personalised narrative of the history of her village. Women introduced themselves stating their name, village name, family details, their reasons for being in the *sangha*, as well as any personal message they had to share with the audience.

This year saw MSK take up much greater ownership of *Kelu Sakhi*. Apart from integrating the *Kelu Sakhi* programmes more closely in their regular work, MSK's

field staff have learnt to record and have started producing broadcast quality programmes. MSK has constituted an internal committee for *Kelu Sakhi* to take care of all these aspects of the radio programme.

Over the year, the CCID team completed the process of training and initial hand-holding for *Vikasana*, a grassroots NGO based in Mandya district, for developing their own community radio programmes. *Vikasana* is a 25-year old organisation working in the area of watershed development, livelihoods, organic farming, child labour, gender and education. The CCID team trained the *Vikasana* team on recording, editing, scripting and on content management. *Vikasana* now has its own recording team, editing team, scripting team and a core management team that will supervise their community radio activities. They are well on their way to build the initial content bank before live broadcasts of their programmes begin, which is expected to take place within a few months.

Community Video

MSK women continued to actively participate in making and watching videos on issues that directly concern them. A total of 16 videos were made during the year under review. In addition, many videos on various subjects developed by other agencies were also used.

Mahila Samakhya Karnataka's (MSK) field workers carry a set of videos with them during their village visits. These videos help support their agenda of discussing important issues at *sangha* meetings. *Sangha* women organise the audio-visual equipment from their own homes or from the village. They often request MSK workers for a repeat

Use of local instruments and the local dialect is very good. I like this programme.

Rame Gouda,
Government official from
Channarayana, Hassan
District, Karnataka

Watching a video makes it easier to talk about issues

Hema, Attiguppe village,
Hunsur Taluk, Karnataka

viewing of videos. Videos are also screened during block³ level meetings organised by MSK, where MSK personnel facilitate discussions initiated around the issues presented in the videos. *Sangha* women organise community screenings of videos that they determine are important for the whole community. These screenings are usually in the night, with a projector. The entire community gathers for these screenings, which often end with requests for more such screenings. These community screenings help strengthen a leadership role for *sangha* women in the community, which consequently has obvious implications for gender relations.

The impact of community videos is growing and reaching beyond the local community. Many government departments are beginning to see that locally made videos providing relevant information about their work helps them function better in serving the community. Popularity of videos made on the role and work of some departments is acting as both a pressure and an incentive for other departments who were initially more reluctant in this regard. Men from the village have even started to participate in viewing videos at *sangha* meetings and also share their opinions concerning various issues. Screening of

Some positive outcomes from the community video	
In <i>K.R. Nagara</i> block, women watched the 'Bank and <i>Sangha</i> ' video whereby they were able to access bank loans without any assistance from MSK personnel.	After watching a video, a non- <i>sangha</i> villager accessed a subsidy for setting up a flour mill from a government department.
After watching the video about <i>Kelu Sakhi</i> , two women from <i>Melur</i> village belonging to an older generation, bought a radio to enable collective listening.	After watching a video on literacy, two women from <i>Muskere</i> village, joined a literacy camp, learnt to read and write and went for an evaluation. However, they did not pass the test. The women did not give up, practised and cleared the test the next time.
A girl who had dropped out of school from <i>Somnalli</i> watched a video about the importance of the education of the girl child and the facilities available through <i>Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan</i> , and decided to go back to school. This video has also helped the MSK staff in their school enrolment campaign.	Women <i>sangha</i> members from <i>Periyapatna</i> Block went to the horticulture department after watching a video on the schemes of the department and sought help for growing flowers. After learning about the possibilities, they asked the village elders to allot some village land to the <i>sangha</i> where they could grow flowers.

3 A block is an administrative unit consisting of a few scores of villages.

videos has started to attract women to cluster meetings (involving a couple of adjacent villages) and thus enabling MSK field workers to hold such meetings much more regularly.

Community Computing

During the year under review, the CCID team worked with three village level community telecentres that the *sangha* women refer to as *Namma Mahiti Kendras*, (Our Information Centres), at *Attiguppe*, *Hosavaranchi* and *Bannikuppe* villages, and two block level centres at *Hunsur* and *H.D. Kote*.

Namma Mahiti Kendras (NMKs) have steadily come to have a strong influence on the information and communication architecture of the local village community (the local community informatics). *Sangha* women from the village level NMKs have started to become much more active in community activities, because of their widely acknowledged leadership in community informational matters as well as linkages with government departments.

Some of the areas where *sangha* women have shown increased participation is concerning the *gram panchayat*, the school development and monitoring committee, the *anganwadi* (village creche) monitoring committee and the village hygiene and health committee.

Each NMK covers five to six surrounding villages. A village information worker, called *Sakhi* (friend), manages each NMK, while a management committee consisting of *sangha* women and few other village leaders provides overall direction. The *Sakhi* visits all the villages covered by an NMK. She shares information about services available at the NMK with the community. The *Sakhi*

goes from house to house and inquires about the kind of information needed by the community. She also shares her knowledge about government departments and other useful information. The requests for information have ranged from 'how to get a bus pass' to 'how to get jobs for our children'. Requests for agriculture related information, pertaining to seeds, saplings, free manure and subsidised ploughs, pumps, motors and sprinkler pipes are very common. The proactive engagement of the *Sakhi* often draws the interest of villagers and they follow up for more information regarding different agencies by visiting the NMKs. Apart from providing the required information, the *Sakhi* also helps villagers apply for entitlements like old age pension, widow pension, disability pension etc., and assists in processing applications.

The NMK and Block level (a sub-district unit) *Sakhis* work in tandem. The Block level *Sakhi* is the principal conduit to government departments and other agencies like banks. *Sangha* women from NMK villages have slowly begun to assert complete control and ownership of NMK activities. They pool in the money earned from NMKs, through revenue-generating activities like computer education, digital photography, data entry etc, into a corpus called the '*Bhavishya Nidhi*' (future fund). *Sangha* women are increasingly confident of running NMKs on their own. They are reaching out to nearby villages, spreading information about the centre as well as coaxing people to give their photo/video orders to the centre, so that it can keep earning some revenue. They are also taking up many new community-oriented activities which can benefit the local community while strengthening their *sangha*.

We have been very impressed at how you use information to help citizens and hold the government accountable. We wish you success in the future.

Steven Solnick,
Representative of Ford
Foundation, New Delhi

I tried three or four times to get myself a certificate and avail of the disability pension but I was not able to get it. Now because of you (NMK *Sakhi*), I am getting Rs. 1,000 every month. I will never forget you.

Puttamma, Physically
challenged woman,
Somanalli, Mysore District,
Karnataka

Extremely good initiative. Good to know that women of the region are utilising the benefits of this programme to the maximum. Such initiatives definitely help in the upliftment and empowerment of the community. Wishing the programme good luck, God bless.

*Dr. Ratan Kelkar, Director,
Kerala IT mission*

*Handycam training,
Kishori Chitrapata
project, Attiguppe
Village, Hunsur Taluk,
Mysore District,
Karnataka*

Attiguppe NMK women organised a blood check up for all women at the village NMK. Some women from this NMK plan to buy a tractor at subsidised rates, through a government scheme and rent it to the community members especially to small and marginal farmers who are unable to afford renting tractors at the going market price. In *Hosavaranchi*, the NMK accommodated a group of women builders who stayed in the centre and built toilets for the the entire residential area of a disadvantaged caste.

As *sangha* women are now able to guide community members regarding government information, entitlements and other schemes, this has meant a lot for their status in the community. Villagers, including men, are often found approaching *sangha* women for various kinds of information. *Sangha* women are now much more sought after for a larger role in community activities. On the other hand, as they have become more active in leadership roles in the village, *sangha* women have also grown more aware of social inequities and injustices and are trying to bridge the gap through their endeavours.

Community Informatics and Education

CCID began a new project, *Kishori Chitrapata* (images by adolescent girls) this year to address the learning needs of out of school adolescent girls or *kishoris*. This project is being done in partnership with MSK, UNICEF and *Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan*⁴, Karnataka. The project explores the innovative uses of video, radio and computing technology for constructivist learning by these young girls. The girls explore their natural and social ecologies through this technology. This process helps them develop self-confidence, a spirit of enquiry, critical thinking and reflection. It opens up new processes as well as avenues of learning for them through relating critically to their immediate environment. The project also aims to help *kishoris* develop radio and video programmes about important community issues, which are then presented to the community for their reflection. This process is likely to create a new empowering role and position for these young girls, who otherwise live on the periphery of the community.

Adolescent girls constitute a highly sensitive group in the village. Most issues concerning adolescence, especially those related to girls, whether they are of bodily changes, sexuality and personal relationships or about their own choices regarding education, career and marriage, never find space in public dialogue. This project seeks to develop such spaces using ICTs, which can nurture the journey of this highly disempowered group towards empowerment, in small but sure steps, while also taking the community along. Community involvement has been seen as key to bring *kishoris* out of their homes, the space in which they mostly remain confined.



4 *Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan* is India's flagship nationwide education program.

The first stage of the project is being implemented at two villages, *Attiguppe* and *Hosavaranchi*, of *Hunsur* Block in *Mysore*. Both these villages have community telecentres or NMKs. The *sangha* women of the village and the NMK *Sakhi* constitute crucial support structures for the implementation of the project.

Most of the CCID team needed to be oriented afresh as trainers for all three kinds of technology – video, radio and computers – that are being used in the project. *Sangha* women were given an orientation session to act as a support group for the project. We engaged parents of the girls in repeated conversations to explain why their daughters should participate in the programme, allaying their misgivings in this regard. It was equally important to gain the support of village elders because projects involving adolescent girls carry many social risks.

A full scale curriculum was developed for the education of the girls in a participatory manner, involving the girls, *sangha* women and MSK staff, thus practicing a constructivist approach to education. The issues chosen range from life skills to reproductive health, gender, dowry, alcoholism, basic science, agriculture and government programmes.

Activities at Hosavaranchi Village

In *Hosavaranchi*, *Kishoris* readily agreed to video shoot the process of door-to-door visits by the NMK *Sakhi* for the collection of various informational needs. Traditionally, upper caste areas of the village have been out of bounds for disadvantaged castes. When *kishoris* of disadvantaged castes visited dominant caste areas with a video camera, curious questions were asked about whose daughters they were and what is that they were doing with the camera. Dominant caste members, however,

supported the process; they even agreed to let *kishoris* eat the fruit from their trees. After the visit, *kishoris* said that it was the first time they saw how big their village was and who all lived in it.

The *kishoris* themselves prepared the questionnaire for the video shoot, starting from basic questions like ‘what is information’. The framing of such questions and posing them has been an extraordinary experience; it has helped *kishoris* who had dropped out of school develop confidence and the faculties of critical thinking and inquiry as perhaps no formal system of education could provided.

When the *gram panchayat* elections were round the corner, *kishoris* organised a video shoot around the elections. They prepared questions and interviewed *sangha* women. The following are some of the comments made by the *kishoris* after the interviews:

- ‘I did not know that there were different types of elections happening, I thought once in 5 years people gathered at the school to vote for the government’
- ‘I have never voted though I am older than 18 years’
- ‘*Gram panchayat* elections are so important’

*Digicam training,
Kishori Chitrapata
project, Hosavaranchi
Village, Hunsur Taluk,
Mysore District,
Karnataka*



Those who have completed their studies are like this (confident). I feel happy that with this training I am able to reach the level (of confidence) that is usually possessed by those who have studied. In fact, I feel I know more than that.

Asha, a Kishori, who dropped out of school and later joined the Kishori Chitrapata project, sending a message through community video to other Kishoris, Hosavaranchi Village, H.D. Kote Taluk, Karnataka

Another topic they chose to make a video on was 'the importance of forests'. They had heard from their elders that there used to be a forest on the outskirts of their village and that it was cleared a few decades ago. Their initial objective was to bring out the message that it is good to preserve trees and forests. During the course of the interview, however, they learnt that elephants from the forest frequently damaged the crops and had even mauled some people. This was the reason why the village community had decided to clear the forest. This pushed the *kishoris* to think critically and they realised that there are no easy answers to many social, ecological and political questions in their specific manifestations.

Activities at Attiguppe Village

In Attiguppe, when *kishoris* were learning about the concept of ambient light while taking still pictures on the camera, one of the exercises given to them was to photograph a petty shop. However, it so happened that the only petty shop in the village was closed that day. A male community member, who saw the *kishoris* returning disappointed because the petty shop was closed, suggested that they could take photographs of his shop instead. His was a barber's shop, a veritable male domain. For the first time, women entered a completely male space in the village. This became possible because they had a digital camera in their hands.

Initially, *kishoris* refused to go out for such outdoor exercises because they were shy and apprehensive about the reactions of adult men and women in the village. They were painfully conscious of the social norms that restricted their mobility. After a few positive and empowering experiences, *kishoris* now readily take to the village

streets, planning and completing their outdoor assignments themselves. They know that when they face any problems, they have *sangha* women to turn to for counsel and support.

Kishoris now move around freely in their village. The community knows about their work and appreciates it. Villagers pitch in to support by posing for photographs, by participating in interviews and by making themselves available for video shoots etc. Community acknowledgement and tacit consent has served to legitimise the new found mobility and learning avenues for the *kishoris*.

Looking Ahead

There has been a drying up of funding in the ICTD area which has been almost as rapid as the advent and rise of ICTD funding in the early years of this decade. ICTD did largely fail in its promise because of the certain distance that this new field has kept from the more traditional precepts and practices of development. The current thinking in donor circles is that it is best to directly fund ICT related activity within, and as a part of, project funding in different sectors like governance, gender, education, health etc. However, it is our experience that a specialised agency is needed, which can evangelise ICT possibilities in the development field and build capacity as well as do some hand holding for development agencies working in different sectors. It is important to create new informational cultures that enable greater empowerment of the local community, challenging the influences of the global that render powerless, the local, and also dismantle exploitative social structures that keep some sections of society in perpetual disadvantage. Getting funding support for a CCID focussed kind of agency is difficult, and though we do get funds for specific

areas like gender, education and governance, some committed core funding for CCID is needed for us to work with greater confidence to meet its objectives as a resource group for a range of development activities.

We plan to extend the *Kishori Chitrapata* project to two large-scale government initiatives that seek to incorporate girls who have dropped out of school back into the school system, through residential schools. These two initiatives are the *Mahila Shikshana Kendra* of MSK, and the *Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vasathi Kendra* of the *Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan* of the Government of Karnataka. Both these initiatives provide residential schools to help girls from disadvantaged sections continue in the formal education system. In these initiatives the *Kishori Chitrapata* project will be part of the formal classroom based education process. Therefore, the project will adapt to this situation. The curriculum and pedagogical processes will integrate into the school's regular activities. The opportunity is to demonstrate how ICTs can be used as part of the formal educational process to employ local content in a constructivist manner to enhance learning outcomes. Since a lot of ICTs in schools programmes are being designed currently, there is a

Signs of change

Parents of *Kishoris* and the husband of one married *kishori* spoke for a video which showcased the learning gains *kishoris* were making through the *Kishori Chitrapata* project. They mentioned how these girls were benefitting from this training and urged other parents not to hesitate in allowing their daughters to participate and gain from it.

A majority of the *kishoris* in the project are now able to negotiate with their elders for the postponement of marriage for upto two years. All *kishoris* also articulated the desire to take up employment before they got married. The mother of one *kishori* said that she is willing to send her daughter to work as it is good for her. She had seen NMK *sakhi* work and saw it as an opportunity to earn for the family. This statement, coming from a mother who had earlier pulled her daughter out of school, carries weight.

good advocacy opportunity through this project, especially since we are also working along with government education programmes.

IT for Change is planning to start a new field project, *Khuli Panchayat* (open local self-governance system), next year, through CCID. This proposed project will look at new community informatics processes that can deepen democracy at the local level and increase the local community's engagement with various governance processes as well as with specific government programmes like the Rural Health Mission and the National Rural Employment Guarantee Programme.